

Word family: **erase / erases / erased / erasing / erasure / erasable**

Base word: erase

Part of speech: mainly **verb**

Related forms:

* **erase** (v.) — 擦去；抹掉；刪除；消除

* **erased** (adj./participle) — 已擦除的；已刪除的

* **erasing** (n./gerund) — 擦除；刪除

* **erasure** (n.) — 擦除；刪除；抹去

* **erasable** (adj.) — 可擦除的；可刪除的

* **eraser** (n., mainly AmE) — 擦膠 / 橡皮擦

Useful expressions / extensions:

* **erase pencil marks**

* **erase writing**

* **erase something from a board**

* **erase a file**

* **erase data**

* **erase a memory**

* **erase the past**

* **erase all evidence**

* **erase a mistake**

* **erase someone's identity/history**

* **erase from memory**

* **erase from existence**

* **digital erasure**

* **complete erasure**

Meaning in this passage

> Of course, an apology does not **erase everything overnight**...

Here, **erase** is figurative.

It means:

make the effects, hurt, or memory of what happened disappear completely — 抹去；消除

The apology helped repair trust, but it did not instantly remove all the emotional consequences of the incident.

****中文翻譯：****

當然，道歉並不能一夜之間****抹走所有事情 / 消除所有傷害****。

So here:

**erase = 令某件事留下的痕跡、影響或記憶完全消失**

1. **erase (擦去字跡 / 記號) — 擦去 ; 抹掉**

The core literal sense.

Practice 1

> Please ****erase the pencil marks****.

請把鉛筆痕****擦掉****。

Practice 2

> She ****erased the answer**** and wrote it again.

她把答案****擦掉****再重新寫。

Practice 3

> The teacher ****erased the board****.

老師把白板上的字****擦掉了****。

****MCQ-ready definition:****

****erase = 用擦膠、布等把文字、線條或記號從表面移除****

2. **erase something from a board — 從板上擦掉某物**

Practice 1

> He ****erased the diagram from the board****.

他把圖表從板上****擦掉****。

Practice 2

> Don't **erase my notes from the whiteboard** yet.

先不要把我的筆記從白板上**擦走**。

MCQ-ready definition:

erase X from Y = 把 X 從某個表面上移除

3. **erase a mistake — 擦掉錯誤**

Practice 1

> I **erased the mistake** and corrected it.

我把錯誤**擦掉**再改正。

Practice 2

> Use a pencil so you can **erase mistakes**.

用鉛筆吧，這樣犯錯時可以**擦掉重寫**。

MCQ-ready definition:

erase a mistake = 把寫錯的內容擦去

4. **erase (數碼：刪除檔案 / 資料) — 刪除；清除**

A major modern sense.

Practice 1

> I accidentally **erased the file**.

我不小心把檔案**刪除了**。

Practice 2

> The device **erases old data** automatically.

裝置會自動**清除舊資料**。

MCQ-ready definition:

****erase digital data = 從電子裝置或儲存媒體中刪除資料****

5. ****erase data — 清除資料****

Practice 1

> Make sure all personal data is ****erased**** before selling the phone.

出售電話前，確保所有個人資料已被****清除****。

Practice 2

> The command will ****erase all data**** on the drive.

這個指令會****清除磁碟上的所有資料****。

****MCQ-ready definition:****

****erase data = 把電子資料從儲存裝置中移除****

6. ****erase a file — 刪除檔案****

Practice 1

> She ****erased the wrong file**** by mistake.

她不小心****刪錯了檔案****。

Practice 2

> Once the file is ****erased****, recovery may be difficult.

檔案一旦被****刪除****，可能很難復原。

****MCQ-ready definition:****

****erase a file = 把一個電子檔案從儲存位置中移除****

7. ****erase (錄音 / 影像：抹去記錄) — 抹除；清除****

A classic media-storage sense.

Practice 1

> The old recording was accidentally **erased**.

舊錄音被意外**抹掉了**。

Practice 2

> Be careful not to **erase the footage**.

小心不要把影片素材**刪掉 / 抹除**。

MCQ-ready definition:

erase a recording = 移除已錄製的聲音或影像內容

8. **erase (figurative : 消除影響) — 消除 ; 抹去**

This is the exact branch used in your passage.

Practice 1 — original sentence

> An apology does not **erase everything overnight**.

道歉不會一夜之間**消除所有影響**。

Practice 2

> One kind act cannot **erase years of hurt**.

一次善意行為不能**抹去多年的傷害**。

Practice 3

> Time did not completely **erase the pain**.

時間並沒有完全**消除那份痛楚**。

MCQ-ready definition:

erase = figurative: 令過去事件留下的影響、傷害或痕跡消失

9. **erase a memory — 抹去記憶**

Practice 1

> I wish I could **erase that memory**.

我真希望可以**抹去那段記憶**。

Practice 2

> The years did not **erase the memory** of what happened.

多年過去仍沒有**抹去那件事的記憶**。

****MCQ-ready definition:****

****erase a memory = 令某段記憶完全消失，通常為比喻用法****

10. **erase something from memory — 從記憶中抹去**

Practice 1

> He tried to **erase the incident from his memory**.

他試圖把那件事**從記憶中抹去**。

Practice 2

> Some moments are impossible to **erase from memory**.

有些時刻很難**從記憶中抹走**。

****MCQ-ready definition:****

****erase X from memory = 令自己不再記得 X****

11. **erase the past — 抹去過去**

Practice 1

> You cannot **erase the past**, but you can learn from it.

你不能**抹去過去**，但可以從中學習。

Practice 2

> An apology cannot simply **erase the past**.

一句道歉不能簡單地**抹掉過去**。

MCQ-ready definition:

erase the past = 令過去曾發生的事情或其影響彷彿不存在

12. **erase the damage / hurt — 消除傷害**

Practice 1

> The apology helped, but it didn't **erase the hurt**.

道歉有幫助，但沒有完全**消除傷害**。

Practice 2

> Money cannot always **erase emotional damage**.

金錢並不總能**消除情感傷害**。

MCQ-ready definition:

erase hurt/damage = 令受傷或負面影響完全消失

13. **erase evidence — 抹去 / 消除證據**

Practice 1

> Someone tried to **erase the evidence**.

有人試圖**抹去證據**。

Practice 2

> Deleting the message did not completely **erase the evidence**.

刪除訊息並沒有完全**消除證據**。

MCQ-ready definition:

erase evidence = 刻意移除會顯示某件事曾發生的痕跡或資料

14. **erase traces / signs — 抹去痕跡**

Practice 1

> The rain **erased most of the footprints**.

雨水**沖走 / 抹去了大部分腳印**。

Practice 2

> Renovation **erased many signs of the old building**.

翻新工程**抹去了很多舊建築的痕跡**。

MCQ-ready definition:

erase traces/signs = 令某物曾經存在的痕跡消失

15. **erase someone's identity — 抹去某人的身份 / 特質**

A strong figurative use.

Practice 1

> The policy risked **erasing local identity**.

這項政策有可能**抹去地方身份認同**。

Practice 2

> Translation should not **erase the writer's voice**.

翻譯不應**抹掉作者原有的聲音 / 風格**。

MCQ-ready definition:

erase identity/voice = 令某人或群體的獨特特徵、存在感或身份被消除

16. **erase history — 抹去歷史；淡化歷史存在**

Practice 1

> Removing the monument does not **erase history**.

移除紀念碑並不會**抹去歷史**。

Practice 2

> The archive preserves stories that might otherwise be **erased from history**.

檔案館保存了一些否則可能會**從歷史中被抹去**的故事。

****MCQ-ready definition:****

****erase history = 令過去的人、事件或記錄不再被看見、記得或承認****

17. ****erase from existence — 徹底消滅；令不復存在****

A strong figurative expression.

Practice 1

> The village was almost **erased from existence** by the disaster.

災難幾乎令村莊**徹底消失**。

Practice 2

> The old system was effectively **erased from existence**.

舊制度實際上被**徹底淘汰**。

****MCQ-ready definition:****

****erase X from existence = 徹底消除 X，使其不再存在****

18. ****eraser — 擦膠；橡皮擦****

Mainly AmE term.

Practice 1

> Can I borrow your **eraser**?

可以借你的**擦膠**嗎？

Practice 2

> This pencil has an **eraser** on the end.

這支鉛筆尾端有一塊**擦膠**。

MCQ-ready definition:

eraser = 用來擦掉鉛筆字跡的物件

BrE note: **rubber** is traditionally common in British English, though **eraser** is widely understood.

19. **erasable** — 可擦除的；可刪除的

Practice 1

> This pen uses **erasable ink**.

這支筆使用**可擦墨水**。

Practice 2

> The data is fully **erasable**.

這些資料可以完全**刪除**。

MCQ-ready definition:

erasable = 可以被擦去、抹除或刪除的

20. **erasable pen / ink** — 可擦筆 / 可擦墨水

Practice 1

> I use an **erasable pen** for notes.

我用**可擦筆**寫筆記。

Practice 2

> The **erasable ink** disappears with friction.

這種**可擦墨水**經摩擦後會消失。

****MCQ-ready definition:****

****erasable pen/ink = 寫下後仍可被特殊方式擦除的筆 / 墨水****

21. ****erasure (擦除 ; 抹除) — 擦除 ; 刪除****

Practice 1

> The ****erasure**** of the data was permanent.

資料的****刪除****是永久的。

Practice 2

> The document showed signs of ****erasure****.

文件上有****擦除痕跡****。

****MCQ-ready definition:****

****erasure = 把文字、資料、記號等擦去或刪除的行為或結果****

22. ****erasure (figurative : 抹去存在 / 身份) — 抹除 ; 被忽略至消失****

A strong academic/cultural extension.

Practice 1

> The book discusses the ****erasure of minority voices****.

這本書討論少數群體聲音被****抹去 / 忽視****的問題。

Practice 2

> Historical ****erasure**** can make certain communities invisible.

歷史上的****抹除****可能令某些社群變得彷彿不存在。

****MCQ-ready definition:****

****erasure = figurative: 令某些人的身份、歷史、聲音或存在被忽略、刪除或看不見****

Important distinction 1: ****erase vs delete****

erase

originally physical wiping away, and often emphasizes **removing traces/content**.

delete

especially digital/textual removal.

> erase pencil marks

> 擦掉鉛筆痕

> delete a file

> 刪除檔案

For digital data, they overlap substantially, though **erase** can suggest more complete wiping.

Important distinction 2: **erase vs remove**

remove

very broad: take something away.

erase

specifically make marks, data, traces, memories, etc. disappear.

> remove the paper from the desk

把紙從桌上拿走

> erase the writing on the paper

擦掉紙上的字

Important distinction 3: **erase vs wipe**

wipe

physical motion of rubbing a surface.

erase

result of removing writing/data/traces.

> wipe the board

抹白板

> erase the writing

擦掉字跡

In computing, **"wipe a drive"** often means securely erase all data.

Important distinction 4: **"erase vs clear"**

"clear"

remove contents or make space/visibility clear.

"erase"

delete existing marks/data.

> clear the screen

清除畫面

> erase the file

刪除檔案

They overlap in technical interfaces.

Important distinction 5: **"erase vs forget"**

"forget"

memory disappears naturally or unintentionally.

"erase a memory"

suggests deliberate or complete removal, often figurative.

> I forgot the date.

我忘了日期。

> I wish I could erase the memory.

我希望可以抹去那段記憶。

Important distinction 6: **erase** vs **undo**

undo

reverse a recent action.

erase

remove content.

> undo the last edit

復原上一個修改動作

> erase the paragraph

刪掉那段文字

An apology cannot **undo** the past either, but **erase** emphasizes removing its traces/effects.

Important distinction 7: **erase** vs **repair**

Very relevant to your passage.

erase hurt

make the hurt disappear.

repair damage

fix what was damaged.

An apology may **repair trust** without fully **erasing the hurt**.

That distinction is exactly what your sentence expresses.

Important distinction 8: **erase** vs **restore**

Also directly relevant.

erase

remove something.

restore

bring something back.

In the passage:

> apology **restored trust**

> but did not **erase everything**

Beautiful semantic contrast:

* **restore** = bring back something good

* **erase** = remove something bad

Important distinction 9: **erase evidence** vs **destroy evidence**

erase evidence

remove traces/data, especially records.

destroy evidence

physically or otherwise render evidence unusable.

Destroy is broader and stronger.

Important distinction 10: **erase history** does not literally change the past

It means:

remove records, recognition, or public memory of it

The historical event itself still happened.

Important distinction 11: **erasure vs omission**

omission

something is left out.

erasure

often suggests stronger removal or making something/someone effectively invisible.

Erasure can therefore carry a stronger social/cultural meaning.

Family-extension note

Erase has a very clear semantic core:

remove something so that it is no longer visible, present, recorded, or felt

That branches into:

1. **physical marks**

- * erase pencil

- * erase board

2. **digital information**

- * erase file

- * erase data

3. **recordings**

- * erase footage

- * erase audio

4. **emotional effects**

* erase hurt
* erase the past

5. **memory**

* erase a memory
* erase from memory

6. **traces/evidence**

* erase evidence
* erase signs

7. **identity/history**

* erase identity
* historical erasure

8. **complete disappearance**

* erase from existence

For your passage, the exact branch is:

erase = completely remove the emotional and relational effects of what happened

Master comparison

Form / expression	Traditional Chinese	Core idea	
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erase (writing)	擦掉	remove marks	
erase from a board	從板上擦掉	physical removal	
erase a mistake	擦掉錯誤	written correction	
erase a file	刪除檔案	digital removal	
erase data	清除資料	digital deletion	
erase a recording	抹除錄音 / 影像	recorded content	
erase hurt	消除傷害	emotional effect	
erase the past	抹去過去	figurative removal	
erase a memory	抹去記憶	memory	
erase from memory	從記憶中抹去	forget completely	
erase evidence	抹去證據	remove traces	
erase traces	抹去痕跡	remove signs	
erase identity	抹去身份	remove distinctiveness	
erase history	抹去歷史	remove recognition/records	

erase from existence	徹底消滅	total removal	
eraser	擦膠 / 橡皮擦	tool	
erasable	可擦除的	removable	
erasable ink	可擦墨水	physical writing	
erasure	擦除；刪除	act/result	
erasure (figurative)	抹除；被忽略	identity/history removal	

For your original sentence

> Of course, an apology does not **erase everything overnight**, but when it is honest, timely, and specific, it can really mend the situation.

Here:

erase everything = 把那次誤會、公開指責所造成的尷尬、難受和信任受損全部立即消除

The sentence deliberately does **not** say:

> an apology fixes everything instantly.

Instead:

> it can **restore trust**

> but it cannot immediately **erase every emotional consequence**

A natural Traditional Chinese rendering is:

> 當然，道歉並不能一夜之間**抹走所有事情 / 消除所有傷害**，但只要它是真誠、及時而且具體的，就真的可以修補局面。

The strongest contrast is:

> **restore trust** = 把失去的信任帶回來

> **erase hurt** = 把留下的傷害完全消除

An apology may do the first before it fully does the second.